

PREGNANT FOR MY COLD-HEARTED BILLIONAIRE

BY
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CHAPTER 1

The Night Everything Changed

The music was too loud.

Emma Hart stood at the edge of the crowded ballroom, holding a glass of champagne she hadn't touched. She didn't belong here. She knew it. Her plain black dress was nothing compared to the designer gowns floating around her. Her heels were borrowed. Even her smile was forced.

She was only here because her boss had insisted.

"Smile, Emma. Network. This is how careers are built," he had said.

Easy for him to say. He owned three companies. She could barely pay her rent.

She took a small sip of champagne and winced. Too bitter. Just like everything else about tonight.

"You look like you'd rather be anywhere else."

The voice came from beside her. Deep. Smooth. Calm, like a man who had never been nervous a day in his life.

Emma turned.

And her breath stopped.

He was tall. Broad shoulders. Dark hair pushed back perfectly. His suit was black and fitted like it had been sewn onto his body. He wasn't smiling. He was just... looking at her. Like she was the only person in the entire room worth looking at.

Emma blinked. *Say something. Say anything.*

"I was thinking the same about you," she heard herself say.

One eyebrow lifted. A ghost of a smile crossed his lips.

"Alexander," he said simply.

No last name. No title. Just Alexander, like that was enough. And somehow, it was.

"Emma," she replied.

He looked at her champagne glass. *"You haven't drunk it."*

"It tastes like regret."

This time he actually smiled. Small. Brief. But real.

"Come," he said. *"I know where they keep the better bottles."*

She should have said no. She didn't know this man. She was here to network, not follow strangers through crowded ballrooms. She had work tomorrow morning. An early meeting. A report half-finished on her laptop at home.

She followed him anyway.

They ended up on a private balcony on the 30th floor, away from the noise and the fake laughter below. The city stretched out beneath them, golden lights, moving cars, the quiet hum of a world that didn't care about any of them.

Alexander poured two glasses of red wine from a bottle that probably cost more than Emma's monthly salary.

She didn't ask how he got access to this balcony. Something told her Alexander Steele had access to everywhere he wanted to go.

"So," she said, wrapping both hands around her glass. *"What do you actually do? Besides rescue women from terrible champagne?"*

"I run things," he said simply.

Emma laughed. *"That's very vague."*

"Most important things are."

She looked at him sideways. He was staring at the city below, jaw set, eyes distant, like he was somewhere else entirely. Like even here, even now, something heavy was sitting on his shoulders.

"You don't enjoy these events either," she said softly. It wasn't a question.

He glanced at her. *"No."*

"Then why come?"

A long pause. *"Obligation."*

Emma nodded slowly. She understood obligation. She understood doing things because you had to, not because you wanted to. She understood smiling when you were tired. Staying when you wanted to leave.

"Me too," she whispered.

Something shifted in his eyes then. Something she couldn't name. He looked at her — really looked at her, and for one strange, breathless moment, Emma felt completely seen.

Not her dress. Not her job title. Not her resume.

Her.

She didn't mean for the night to go the way it did.

One glass of wine became two. Two became conversation that flowed easier than anything Emma had experienced in years. He was sharp. Quiet. Intense. He didn't say much but when he did, every word landed.

She told him about her mother back in Ohio. About the job she loved but the boss she tolerated. About the dream she kept folding smaller and smaller just to fit inside the life she could afford.

He listened. Actually listened. Without checking his phone. Without looking over her shoulder for someone more important.

By midnight, they were still talking.

By one in the morning, he was looking at her in a way that made her forget every sensible thought she'd ever had.

"Emma." Her name in his mouth sounded different. Heavier. Like it meant something.

"Yes?" she breathed.

He reached out and tucked a loose strand of hair behind her ear. His fingers barely grazed her cheek. Such a small touch. But her whole body responded like lightning had passed through her.

"Stay," he said quietly.

Every logical part of her brain screamed no.

She was a practical girl. A careful girl. She didn't do things like this. She didn't stay with strangers in hotel ballrooms. She didn't let beautiful, mysterious men with sad eyes and expensive wine make her feel like the world had shrunk down to just the two of them on a balcony above a glittering city.

She didn't.

She never had.

"Okay," she whispered.

When Emma woke up the next morning, the sheets beside her were cold.

She sat up slowly. The room was quiet. Expensive. Sunlight cut through the curtains in long golden strips.

She was alone.

On the pillow next to her, where Alexander had been, there was nothing. No note. No number. No goodbye.

Just empty space.

Emma sat there for a long moment, the silence pressing against her chest. Then she got up, got dressed, and walked out of the hotel room with her head high and her heart carefully locked shut.

It was one night, she told herself. *It meant nothing.*

He was nobody.

She would never see him again.

She was sure of it.

She was wrong.

CHAPTER 2

Two Pink Lines

Three months later.

Emma stood in the small bathroom of her apartment, staring at the white plastic stick sitting on the edge of the sink.

She had been standing there for four minutes without moving a single muscle.

She knew because she had been counting. Counting every second the way you count when you are desperately hoping that time will somehow move backwards and undo the last few minutes of your life completely. The way you count when you are not ready to accept what is right in front of your eyes.

Two pink lines.

She picked the test up slowly with fingers that absolutely would not stop shaking no matter how hard she tried to steady them. She held it closer to the light above the mirror. Like maybe the light in this particular corner of the bathroom was different from the light everywhere else. Like maybe if she looked at it from a slightly different angle the second line would quietly disappear and everything would go back to exactly the way it was before.

The second line did not disappear.

It was bold and pink and completely certain of itself in a way that Emma was not certain of anything right now. It stared back at her without apology. Without hesitation. Like it had been waiting patiently for her to stop pretending it was not there.

She set the test back down on the edge of the sink very carefully, like it was something fragile that could shatter if she was not gentle enough. Then she gripped the edge of the

sink with both hands, leaned forward slightly, and stared hard at her own reflection in the mirror above the faucet.

She looked exactly the same as she always did. Same dark brown eyes that her mother always said held too many thoughts at once. Same small straight nose. Same mouth that pressed into a thin line whenever she was trying to stay calm. Same face she had woken up to every single morning for twenty six years of her life.

But nothing was the same.

Everything had changed in the space of three minutes and thirty seconds.

She watched her reflection swallow hard.

"Okay," she whispered to herself very quietly. "Okay. Just breathe Emma. Just breathe."

She breathed in slowly through her nose. Held it. Let it out through her mouth. Then in again. It helped a little. Not enough. But a little.

She had told herself she was being paranoid.

For two full weeks she had been carefully and convincingly telling herself that the exhaustion she felt every afternoon was from staying too late at the office. That the wave of nausea that hit her every single morning before she even got out of bed was because she had been skipping breakfast too often. That the way certain smells made her stomach turn violently was nothing more than stress. She had plenty of stress. Her boss has been difficult lately. The city was loud and expensive and exhausting in ways that never fully left your body.

It was just stress.

It was not this.

But somewhere deep inside her, in a quiet place she had refused to visit or acknowledge or even look at directly, she had already known. The way your body understands things

before your mind is anywhere near ready to catch up. The way something in you shifts and changes and becomes different before you have found the courage to face it.

She had bought the pregnancy test at a small pharmacy exactly two blocks from her office during her lunch break on Wednesday. She had kept her coat collar turned up even though the weather was not particularly cold that day. She had paid with cash so there was no record anywhere. She had walked the entire forty minutes home from work instead of taking the subway just to delay the moment of knowing by a little longer.

She had put the test in the bathroom cabinet and left it there untouched for two more days.

And now she knows.

She was pregnant.

With the child of a man whose last name she did not even know.

Alexander.

That was everything she had. One single first name. Nothing attached to it. No phone number saved anywhere. No business card tucked into her purse. No last name. No address. No way to find him even if she decided she wanted to.

She had worked hard not to think about him after that night. She had been mostly successful at it. Mostly. There were quiet moments here and there, usually late at night when her apartment was too still and too silent, when she would catch herself remembering the way he had sat and listened to her on that balcony like she was the most interesting person he had ever come across. The way his eyes had stayed completely steady on her face the entire time. The small brief smile that had transformed his entire expression for just one unguarded second and made him look like a completely different person underneath all that coldness.

She had pushed every single one of those memories firmly and deliberately back down every time they surfaced.

He had left without a word. Without a note. Without even the most basic human courtesy of a goodbye written on a piece of hotel paper. Whatever she had felt or imagined she felt standing next to him above that glittering city had clearly meant absolutely nothing to him the morning after.

She was nobody to him.

One forgettable night among many.

And now she was carrying his child.

Emma pressed her palm flat and still against her stomach. It was completely flat still. Nothing visible had changed on the outside. But inside, something small and alive and real was already quietly growing. Something that was half her and half a man who did not know her last name or her phone number or that she existed anywhere in the world outside of that one single night.

Her throat tightened.

Her eyes filled with tears before she could do anything to stop them.

Emma did not cry easily or often. She had taught herself a long time ago, back in the small Ohio town where she grew up watching her mother hold everything together alone, that crying did not fix a single problem. It only made your face puffy and your chest feel hollow and your pillow damp in the morning.

But right now, standing in this small bathroom with those two pink lines on the sink and no one waiting in the next room and no one she could call without having to explain everything from the very beginning, the tears came without asking permission.

She let them fall for two full minutes.

Then she wiped her face firmly with the back of her hand. Stood up as straight as she could. Pulled her shoulders back. And looked at herself in the mirror one final time with clear and steady eyes.

"You are going to be okay," she told her reflection in a voice that was quiet but did not waver. "You have survived hard things before. You will survive this too. You always do."

Her reflection stared back at her. It did not look entirely convinced.

Neither was she if she was being completely honest with herself.

But she said it one more time anyway because sometimes you say things out loud not because you fully believe them yet but because you need to start somewhere.

She spent the rest of that evening curled on her small couch with her laptop open on the cushion beside her and a cup of chamomile tea going cold on the coffee table. A thousand thoughts moved through her mind too quickly to grab onto any single one of them long enough to examine it properly.

She needed a plan. Emma always needed a plan. Plans were the scaffolding that kept her standing upright when the ground underneath her felt like it was shifting.

The biggest question sat at the center of everything else and refused to move.

Should she try to find him?

She thought about it with complete seriousness for a long time. She turned it over slowly from every possible angle the way you turn something delicate over in your hands looking for the place where it is strongest.

Alexander owned the hotel. She knew that much. She could go back there. She could ask the right questions of the right people. Someone on that staff would know his full name. Someone could point her in the right direction.

She could find him if she truly decided she wanted to.

But then what would she say? And how would he look at her?

She thought about walking up to a man who had slipped out of a hotel room while she was sleeping without leaving behind a single word. She thought about watching his face carefully rearrange itself into something polite and controlled when she told him. Watching him calculate quickly and quietly the most efficient way to remove himself from her life while causing the least amount of visible inconvenience to his own.

Her stomach turned sharply in the picture.

No.

She would not stand in front of anyone and watch herself become a problem to be solved.

Not for herself. And certainly not for her child.

Her child.

She pressed her hand gently against her stomach again and sat with those two words in the quiet of her apartment for a long and careful moment.

Her child.

Somehow, underneath all of the fear and confusion and the cold tea and the late hour and the blinking cursor on her blank laptop screen, something small and unexpectedly warm settled itself inside her chest. Fragile as a new flame but completely real.

She was terrified. She was more frightened than she had been of anything in her entire adult life.

But she was not alone anymore.

And she was going to make sure that her child never felt alone either. Not for a single day.

She called her mother the next morning.

She sat on the edge of her bed with her phone held in both hands for a long time before she finally pressed the dial. Her mother answered on the second ring the way she always did, her voice warm and familiar and so deeply comforting that Emma came very close to falling apart completely just from the sound of it.

"Emma sweetheart. I was just sitting here thinking about you. How are you doing?"

Emma opened her mouth to say fine. To say work has been busy, nothing much is new, I just called to hear your voice. The safe and simple words she always used.

Instead she heard herself say softly, "Mama. I need to tell you something important."

A brief pause on the line. Then her mother's voice came back quieter and absolutely steady.

"I am right here baby. Take all the time you need."

And Emma, who had been holding herself together carefully with both hands from the moment she saw those two pink lines, finally allowed herself to breathe all the way out.

She was going to need every piece of strength she had ever built.

Because somewhere in this enormous city a cold hearted billionaire was going about his life completely unaware that everything was about to change.

For both of them.

CHAPTER 3

The Last Man She Expected

Four years later.

Emma had learned that life did not wait for you to feel ready.

It just kept moving forward whether you were prepared or not. Whether your heart was healed or still quietly breaking in places you did not like to look at too closely. Whether you had everything figured out or were still making it up one day at a time with a four year old boy on your hip and a packed lunch in your hand and exactly eleven minutes to get out of the apartment before you were late for your first day at a brand new job.

"Mama shoes!" Noah announced very seriously from the hallway.

Emma turned around from the kitchen counter where she had been searching desperately through her bag for her access card. Noah was standing at the front door in his little blue sneakers holding up her black work heels in both hands like he had just discovered something incredibly valuable and important.

Her chest did something soft and warm at the sight of him.

Noah Alexander Hart was four years old and already the most serious and determined little person Emma had ever encountered in her entire life. He had her dark eyes. He had her stubborn mouth that pressed into a firm line when he had made up his mind about something. But everything else about him, the strong jaw, the way he tilted his head slightly when he was thinking, the quiet intensity that sat behind his eyes even when he was playing, all of that came from somewhere else entirely.

From someone else entirely.

Emma did not let herself think about that too long or too often.

She crossed the hallway quickly, slipped her heels on, then crouched down to Noah's level and straightened the collar of his little striped shirt.

"Thank you baby," she said and kissed his forehead. "What would I do without you?"

Noah considered this question with great seriousness. "You would forget things," he concluded.

Emma laughed. "You are absolutely right."

She stood up, grabbed her bag and his small backpack, took his hand firmly in hers and opened the front door.

New job. New start. New chapter.

She was ready.

The offices of Sterling Group were located on the twenty second floor of one of the tallest buildings in the city center.

Emma had researched the company thoroughly before applying. Sterling Group was one of the fastest growing investment firms in the country. They were known for being demanding and fast paced and not particularly gentle with people who could not keep up. The salary was almost double what she had been earning at her previous job. The benefits included a daycare facility on the building's fourth floor which was the detail that had made her apply in the first place.

She had spent two weeks preparing for the interview. She had practiced her answers out loud in front of her bathroom mirror every evening after Noah went to sleep. She had gone through three rounds of interviews over four weeks before she got the call.

She had earned this completely on her own.

That mattered to her more than she could easily explain to anyone.

The elevator opened onto a wide bright reception area with high ceilings and floor to ceiling windows that looked out over the entire city. Emma stepped out smoothly, adjusted the strap of her bag on her shoulder and walked towards the front desk with her chin up and her steps steady.

The receptionist smiled and handed her a visitor badge and a small welcome folder. "Ms. Hart. Welcome to Sterling Group. Your manager Sarah will be with you in just a few minutes. Please help yourself to coffee while you wait."

"Thank you," Emma said pleasantly.

She found a seat near the window and looked out at the city spread below her. Four years ago she had sat in a tiny apartment staring at two pink lines and feeling like the ground had disappeared from under her feet entirely. Now she was here. New city apartment. Wonderful son. New job at one of the best firms in the country.

She had rebuilt herself from nothing and she was proud of every single step it had taken to get here.

Her phone buzzed. A message from her mother.

First day! So proud of you my darling. Noah said to tell you he drew a picture of you in a big office. He says you look very important.

Emma smiled so wide her cheeks hurt.

She typed back quickly. Tell him I will frame it on my desk. Love you both.

She dropped her phone back into her bag and looked up.

And the smile on her face disappeared completely.

He walked out of the large corner office at the far end of the floor like he owned everything he could see in every direction.

Because he did.

He was taller than she remembered somehow. Or maybe it was just the way he carried himself, straight and certain and completely unhurried, like a man who had never once needed to rush for anything or anyone in his entire life. The dark suit he wore was immaculate. His jaw was set. His eyes were moving across the floor with the sharp focused expression of someone who was always calculating something.

Emma felt every single thought leave her head at once.

Her fingers tightened around the strap of her bag. Her heart slammed once, very hard, against the inside of her chest. Then it started beating too fast and too loud in a way she could feel all the way up in her throat.

It was him.

Four years. Four complete years of building a new life. Of putting one careful foot in front of the other. Of waking up every morning and choosing to move forward instead of looking back. Of convincing herself that what happened that night was something that belonged to a different version of herself in a different chapter of her life that was now fully closed.

Four years and he was standing thirty feet away from her looking exactly the same as the night she had let herself make the biggest and most life changing mistake of her entire existence.

Alexander.

His eyes moved across the reception area the way they moved across everything, quickly and thoroughly, missing nothing.

And then they stopped.

Directly on her.

Emma did not breathe. She was not entirely sure she was capable of breathing at this particular moment. She sat completely still in the chair by the window with the morning sun coming through the glass behind her and watched his expression very carefully. Something moved behind his eyes. Fast and brief. There and gone so quickly she might have imagined it entirely.

Then his face settled back into the smooth and unreadable expression he had worn when he told her his name on a hotel balcony four years ago like one word was more than enough for anyone to know about him.

He changed direction.

He was walking towards her.

Emma stood up before she fully decided to. Her legs moved on their own. Her heart was doing something completely unhelpful and erratic inside her chest. Her mind was throwing up a hundred thoughts at once and she could not catch a single one.

Run. Stay. Breathe. Do not let him see that your hands are shaking.

He stopped in front of her.

Up close he looked exactly the same. The same dark quiet eyes. The same jaw. The same stillness around him that made everything else feel slightly louder and more chaotic by comparison.

He looked at her for a long moment without speaking.

"Emma Hart," he said finally.

Not a question. He remembered her name. Four years and one night and he had remembered her name and the way he said it made her feel seventeen different things simultaneously in the space of two seconds.

"Mr. Sterling," the receptionist called out from behind the front desk, her voice professionally bright and completely unaware of the fact that the entire world had just tilted sideways. "Ms. Hart is here for her first day. She will be joining the acquisitions team."

Alexander did not look away from Emma's face.

"I know who she is," he said quietly.

Emma lifted her chin. Her voice came out steadier than she had any right to expect given the circumstances.

"Alexander," she said. Just his name. Calm and clear and giving absolutely nothing away. Something shifted in his expression. Too fast to read. Too brief to be certain of.

"I think," he said, his voice low and very controlled, "that we need to talk."

Emma looked back at him with every wall she had built over four careful years standing firm inside her chest.

"I think," she replied quietly, "that you are about four years too late for that."

She watched something move behind his eyes at those words. She watched him look at her the way he had looked at her on that balcony, like he was trying to read something written in a language he did not quite fully understand yet.

He did not know.

He had absolutely no idea.

And Emma had exactly one day to figure out what on earth she was going to do now that the most dangerous man in her past had just become the most unavoidable person in her present.

CHAPTER 4

The Moment He Saw Noah

Emma got through the rest of her first day on pure determination alone.

She smiled at the right moments. She asked the right questions during her team introduction. She took notes in her new notebook with her pen moving steadily across the page even though her mind was somewhere else entirely for most of the morning.

She ate lunch at her new desk and responded to emails and learned where the printer was and where the good coffee machine was hidden on the second floor.

She did all of the normal first day things that normal people did.

And the entire time, in the back of her mind, one single thought sat completely still and refused to move no matter how hard she tried to push it aside.

He was here.

Alexander Sterling was not just a man she had spent one unforgettable night with four years ago. He was not just the name she had never been able to find. He was not just the ghost she had carefully and deliberately packed away into the furthest corner of her memory and sealed shut.

He was her boss.

The owner of the company she had just spent four weeks interviewing to join. The man whose name was on the building she was now sitting in for eight hours every single day. The person who had walked out of that corner office this morning like he owned everything around him.

Because he did.

Sterling Group. Sterling. She had looked it up the moment she got to her desk. She had typed his name into the search bar with fingers that were not entirely steady and watched the results fill her screen one after another. Alexander Sterling. Thirty two years old. Founder and CEO of Sterling Group. One of the most powerful investment firms in the country. Worth an amount of money that made her feel slightly dizzy when she read the number.

The man she had spent one night with on a hotel balcony talking about obligation and dreams and the weight of the city below them was one of the wealthiest men in the entire country.

And he did not know he had a four year old son.

Emma closed the browser and stared at her screen for a long moment.

Then she picked up her pen and went back to work because that was the only thing she knew how to do when everything felt like it was spinning.

She managed to avoid him completely for three full days.

It was not easy. His presence filled the entire floor in a way that had nothing to do with how often he was physically visible. People moved differently when he was nearby.

Conversations became slightly more careful. Posture improved automatically. Even the air in the office seemed to sharpen and become more alert when Alexander Sterling walked through it.

Emma developed a very precise awareness of exactly where he was at any given moment without ever appearing to pay attention to him at all.

She was very proud of this skill.

On the fourth morning she was standing at the coffee machine on the second floor, staring at it while it made its slow and unreliable grinding noise, when she heard footsteps behind her and felt that particular shift in the atmosphere that she had already learned to recognize without turning around.

She did not turn around.

"You are avoiding me," Alexander said from behind her. His voice was exactly as she remembered it. Low and steady and completely certain of itself.

"I am making coffee," Emma replied without turning around. "These are not the same thing."

She heard him come to stand beside her. She kept her eyes on the coffee machine.

"Emma."

"The coffee is almost ready," she said pleasantly.

"Look at me."

She turned then because there was something in his voice that was not quite a request and not quite a demand but something in between that her body apparently still responded to without asking permission from her brain first.

He was looking at her with those dark steady eyes. Up close in the ordinary light of the office kitchen he looked slightly different from the memory she had carried around for four years. There were faint lines at the corners of his eyes that had not been there before. A tightness around his jaw that suggested the years between then and now had not been entirely easy for him either.

Good, a small part of her thought. Then I felt immediately guilty for thinking it.

"We need to talk properly," he said. "Not in the middle of a reception area on your first day."

"I disagree," Emma said calmly. "I think everything that needed to be said between us was said four years ago."

"Nothing was said four years ago."

"Exactly," she replied quietly.

His jaw tightened. She watched him process that. I watched him understand what she meant by it. She saw something move through his expression that looked almost like discomfort and found herself oddly satisfied by it even though she had promised herself she would feel nothing standing near this man.

"I had reasons," he said.

"I am sure you did," Emma said. She picked up her coffee cup when the machine finally finished. "We all have reasons for the things we do. That does not always make them good ones."

She walked back to her desk and did not look back.

It was a Thursday afternoon three weeks into her new job when everything changed. Emma had been working late finishing a report that needed to be sent before the end of business. Most of the floor had already emptied out. The cleaners had come through quietly. The lights had dimmed automatically in the sections where no one was sitting.

She had completely forgotten that today was the one Thursday each month when the fourth floor daycare stayed open late for parents working overtime.

She remembered at six forty five when her phone buzzed with a message from the daycare coordinator.

Hi Ms. Hart. Just checking. Noah is still here waiting. Are you on your way down?

Emma pushed back from her desk immediately, grabbed her bag and walked quickly to the elevator.

She collected Noah from the daycare on the fourth floor, crouching down to hug him properly while he told her with great seriousness and considerable detail about a disagreement he had experienced with another child over the correct way to build a block tower.

"You were both probably right," Emma told him diplomatically.

Noah considered this. "I was more right," he decided.

Emma laughed and took his hand. They walked to the elevator together, Noah's small backpack bouncing on his back, his little sneakers squeaking faintly on the polished floor.

The elevator opened.

Alexander Sterling was standing inside it.

Emma's entire body went still for one sharp second. Then she stepped inside because there was nothing else she could do. Noah walked beside her cheerfully, completely unbothered by the tall serious man standing against the back wall because Noah was four years old and had not yet learned to be intimidated by powerful men in expensive suits.

Emma pressed the lobby button and stared at the doors as they closed.

The elevator began to move.

"Mama," Noah said conversationally, "can we have pasta tonight?"

"Yes baby," Emma said. Her voice came out completely normal. She was very impressed with herself.

"With the cheese on top?"

"With the cheese on top."

Noah nodded seriously, satisfied with this outcome.

Emma felt Alexander's stillness behind her change in quality. It became a different kind of still. The kind of still that happens when a person has seen something that has stopped every other thought in their mind completely dead.

She did not turn around.

She did not need to.

She already knew.

The elevator reached the lobby and the doors opened. Emma took Noah's hand and walked out. Noah waved cheerfully over his shoulder at the tall man in the elevator the way small children wave at strangers without self consciousness or hesitation.

"Bye!" Noah said brightly.

Emma kept walking.

She got through the lobby and through the revolving doors and out onto the busy pavement before she allowed herself to breathe properly. The evening air hit her face cold and sharp and real.

Behind her she heard the revolving door move again.

"Emma."

His voice was different. She had never heard Alexander Sterling sound like that before.

Not that night four years ago. Not in the office kitchen. Not anywhere.

He sounded like a man whose entire world had just shifted on its axis and was still trying to find solid ground under his feet.

She stopped walking.

She did not turn around.

"How old is he?" Alexander asked quietly.

The pavement noise continued around them. People walked past. Taxis moved through traffic. The city kept going exactly as it always did, completely indifferent to the fact that two people were standing on a pavement outside a glass building and everything between them was about to change forever.

Emma closed her eyes for exactly one second.

Then she turned around and looked at Alexander Sterling for the first time without any wall between them at all.

His face was completely unguarded. For once in his controlled and careful life he was not hiding a single thing. His eyes were moving between her face and the little boy standing beside her holding her hand. Back and forth. Back and forth. Like he was putting something together piece by piece and each piece was hitting him harder than the last one.

"Emma," he said again. Softer this time. "How old is he?"

She looked at him steadily.

"Four," she said quietly.

She watched the number land on him like something physical.

She watched Alexander Sterling, one of the most powerful and controlled men in the entire city, go completely and utterly still.

CHAPTER 5

He Has My Eyes

The city kept moving around them.

Taxis honked. People brushed past on the pavement without looking up from their phones. A food vendor on the corner called out to passing office workers. The whole loud and indifferent machinery of the evening rush hour continued exactly as it always did.

Alexander Sterling did not move.

He stood on the pavement outside the building with his jacket open and the evening wind moving through his dark hair and his eyes fixed on Noah with an expression that Emma had never seen on his face before. Not four years ago on that balcony. Not in the office kitchen three weeks ago. Not in any of the brief and carefully controlled interactions they had managed since she walked into his building and turned his ordered world sideways without meaning to.

This was different.

This was a man looking at something that had reached directly into the center of his chest and grabbed hold of something he did not know was there.

Noah looked back at him with calm and curious four year old eyes. He was not shy. He had never been shy. He tilted his head slightly to one side the way he always did when he was studying something he found interesting.

"You are very tall," Noah observed seriously.

Something moved across Alexander's face. There and gone. But Emma caught it.

"So I have been told," Alexander said quietly.

Noah nodded like this was a reasonable and satisfactory response. Then he looked up at Emma. "Mama I am hungry."

"I know baby," Emma said. Her voice was steady. She was holding onto steady with everything she had. "We are going now."

She took one step forward.

"Emma." Alexander's voice stopped her. Not loud. Not sharp. Just completely certain in the way that everything about him was certain. Like the word had weight behind it.

She turned her head but not her whole body. A small and deliberate distinction.

"I need to speak with you," he said.

"Not tonight," she said.

"Emma."

"Not tonight Alexander." She said his name clearly and calmly and looked directly at him when she said it so he understood that she was not asking for his agreement. She was stating a fact. "Noah needs dinner and a bath and a story and his sleep. He is four years old and his evening does not get rearranged because of adult conversations that can wait until tomorrow."

A pause. She watched him look at Noah one more time. Watched something work through his expression that he was very clearly trying to keep controlled and was not entirely succeeding at.

"Tomorrow then," he said finally. "My office. Eight in the morning before the floor fills up."

Emma held his gaze for one long moment.

"Fine," she said quietly.

She took Noah's hand and walked to the taxi stand at the corner without looking back a single time.

Noah fell asleep halfway through his second bedtime story, one small fist curled under his cheek and his dark lashes resting against his skin and his breathing slow and even and completely peaceful.

Emma sat on the edge of his bed for a long time after he fell asleep.

She looked at his face in the soft glow of the little star shaped nightlight on his bedside table. The strong jaw that was already becoming more defined even at four years old. The way his brows pulled together slightly even in sleep like he was working through something important. The dark eyes that were closed now but that looked back at her every morning with a steadiness and an intelligence that took her breath away sometimes.

She had spent four years telling herself that it did not matter. That Noah was hers. That he was whole and loved and completely taken care of and that the absence of his father was something she had managed and would continue to manage and was not a wound that needed to be reopened for anyone.

She had believed it most of the time.

But sitting here now in the quiet of his small bedroom with tomorrow morning waiting for her on the other side of the night, she was not sure what she believed anymore.

She pressed a very gentle kiss to his forehead without waking him.

"I love you more than everything," she whispered. "And I will always do what is best for you. I promise."

Noah slept on, completely untroubled.

Emma wished with her whole heart that she could do the same.

She arrived at the office at seven fifty five the next morning.

She had been awake since five. She had made coffee and sat at her kitchen table in the early quiet and thought through every possible version of this conversation carefully and methodically the way she thought through every difficult thing. She had decided what she would say and what she would not say and where her lines were and that she would not move from behind them no matter what he said or how he said it.

She was prepared.

She knocked on the door of the corner office at exactly eight o'clock.

"Come in," Alexander said.

She opened the door and walked in and closed it behind her.

His office was large and ordered and said everything about him that he would never say about himself out loud. Clean lines. No unnecessary things on the desk. Floor to ceiling windows looking out over the city from twenty two floors up. One single framed photograph on the shelf behind his desk that she could not see clearly from where she was standing.

He was standing at the window with his back to her when she came in. He turned when he heard the door close.

He looked like he had not slept.

Good, that small part of her thought again. And again she pushed it away.

"Sit down," he said.

"I am fine standing," she replied pleasantly.

His jaw moved. He pulled out the chair across from his desk anyway and looked at her. She sat down because she had decided before she came in that she would not spend this

conversation fighting about small things. She needed her energy for the things that actually mattered.

He sat down across from her.

For a moment neither of them said anything. The city moved silently behind him through the glass.

"Tell me," he said finally.

"Tell you what specifically," Emma said. "You are going to need to be more precise than that."

"Is he mine."

Three words. Flat and direct and completely without decoration.

Emma looked at him steadily across the desk. "Yes," she said.

She watched him absorb that. Watched him sit with it for a moment. His hands were flat on the desk in front of him, perfectly still, but something in the set of his shoulders told her that the stillness was costing him something.

"You knew," he said. "You knew who I was when you came to interview here."

"No," she said clearly. "I did not. I researched Sterling Group thoroughly before I applied. I knew the company. I did not connect the name to you until my first morning when I saw you walking out of that office. I had no idea who you were that night four years ago. You told me your first name and nothing else."

Something shifted in his expression. She could not tell if it was belief or something more complicated than that.

"Why did you not find me?" he asked.

Emma looked at him carefully for a moment before she answered. "You left," she said simply. "You got up while I was sleeping and you walked out of that room without leaving a single word behind. Not a note. Not a number. Nothing. You made it very clear that night was exactly what it was to you and nothing more. I was not going to chase a man who had already told me without words exactly where I stood."

The muscle in his jaw moved.

"And when you found out you were pregnant?" he asked. His voice was quieter now.

"I thought about finding you," she said honestly. "I thought about it seriously for a long time. And then I thought about what it would look like to show up in front of a man who had already walked away from me and tell him I was carrying his child. I thought about what that conversation would cost me and I decided I was not willing to pay that price. So I built a life for my son and myself and I did a very good job of it."

She said the last sentence without apology or hesitation because it was true.

Alexander looked at her for a long moment. Then he said quietly, "He has my eyes."

Emma felt those four words land somewhere deep inside her chest in a way she had not prepared for.

"Yes," she said. Her voice came out slightly less steady than the rest of the conversation and she noticed it and hoped he did not. "He does."

Alexander was quiet for a long moment.

When he looked up at her again something had changed in his expression. The controlled and unreadable mask was still there but there were cracks in it now that had not been there before. Real cracks. The kind that happen when something true and large and irreversible has broken through the surface of a carefully maintained exterior.

"I want to know him," he said.

Emma felt her breath catch.

"That is not a decision you get to make alone," she said steadily.

"I am not asking to make it alone," he said. And then, in a voice that she suspected cost him considerably more than he would ever admit out loud, he said, "I am asking you."

Emma looked at Alexander Sterling across the wide desk with the city spread out behind him and four years of her life sitting between them like a river neither of them had crossed yet.

She did not say yes.

She did not say no.

She said, "I need time."

And she meant every word of it.